CHAPTER 2

Walking Methods as a Place-Learning Experience for Participatory Design

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Abstract

Visual and walking methods promote community empowerment by allowing participants to experience, understand and eventually reshape specific local situations. Such knowledge and decision-making aid help create a shared critical consciousness and provide a collective sense of belonging that boosts proactive citizenship. Participatory practices of directed or random walking through different urban areas open for researchers the possibility of interviewing passers-by and locals in order to enquire about their interactions with the environment and to later "draw a picture"

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with observations, emotions, comments and proposals. Visual methods, such as photo-elicitation or photo-voice recordings during or after walking sessions, provide participants with the tools to highlight issues and value the quality of places for future change. Participatory research originated from the aim to democratise decision-making, enhance user engagement and address everyday issues. The objective of participatory design is the development of an iterative approach. This method is actively used in various sectors and design contexts, including architecture and planning, education, heritage studies, ethnography, human geography and tourism. Participatory design frequently uses multiple research techniques and focus groups. Despite its simplicity, the walking method holds some problems that are addressed in this chapter; namely, the challenge of finding individuals who represent the community and choosing a specific transect walk which may restrict the analysis to a particular situation only. The walking method as a place-learning experience is reflected in this chapter based on three different experiences, bringing together cases from Spain, Slovenia and Portugal. In Spain, the location is a rural area of the Valencia region. In Slovenia, the method was conducted in a high-density neighbourhood popularly called the Russian Tsar, located on the northern outskirts of the capital city of Ljubljana. From Portugal, the experiences in Agualva e Mira Sintra, a town on the outskirts of the Lisbon Metropolitan Area with strong suburban characteristics, will be assessed.

Keywords

urban–rural settings – planning – community – place-based experiences – socio-spatial analysis

1 Introduction

Historically, participatory design (PD) was first introduced and applied in the Scandinavian context. Its mission was to foster "democracy", "equality" and "participation" in systems design and in the growing technological automation developments in the society during the 1960s and 1970s (e.g. Ehn, 1989; Greenbaum & Kyng, 1991). PD has its roots in emerging rights in the work-life for a more inclusive and democratic engagement of people in their civil rights, decision-making and place-based values. People not only started to show engagement in global politics and social development but also began to look closer at their own living and work situations as a response to large-scale technological transformations of workplaces, for example, within large industries (Hansen et al., 2021).

The goal was to involve workers and their employers to provide people with better tools and processes to empower workers so that they could perform their work in a better and more satisfactory way and at the same time establish more effective and efficient work processes for the company or organisation (e.g. Gulliksen et al., 1999; Robertson & Simonsen, 2012).

According to Robertson and Simonsen (2012, p. 2), PD has been defined as:

> A process of investigating, understanding, reflecting upon, establishing, developing, and supporting mutual learning between multiple participants in collective "reflection-in-action". The participants typically undertake the two principal roles of users and designers where the designers strive to learn the realities of the users' situation while the users strive to articulate their desired aims and learn appropriate technological means to obtain them.

2 What We Refer to with PD

PD is both a set of design methods, techniques and tools and a process where participants and stakeholders from relevant sectors of the design context collaborate and contribute towards a common goal. "Participation" is a key concept in any design process and deals with at least three different types (Bratteteig & Wagner, 2016, p. 465):

- *Participation in what?* This dimension deals with the depth of participation.
- *What shapes participation?* The influence of context.
- *How participatory is the design result?* This dimension deals with one of the core aspects of participation, increasing users' ability or "power to" influence the result.

PD is about ensuring that stakeholders who use technologies, services or practices, are extensively involved and play a critical role in shaping their design, functions and procedures. The concept of "practice" is important in connection to PD. One of the major characteristics of PD is its flexible and dynamic usage of different and additional (new) tools and methods that can be added and combined in the design process (Teal & French, 2020). Based on the specific purpose of participation (to design a service, object or procedure), the framework gives advice on tools and activities to be used in terms of the form that participation takes.

PD as a social engineering strategy draws on the knowledge of potential users and involves them in the design process. At the same time individuals are involved, they are also representing a group of people and their opinions.

As such, PD moves beyond individuals into larger systems in which groups of people (e.g. end-users, stakeholders) and their collaborative interaction (CI) with technology that also includes social interaction, work tasks and strategies, align with the goals and purpose of the work tasks or everyday life situations (Hansen et al., 2021).

The ability of PD methods in general is to trigger design. Walking methods are common in CI and in PD it has also been used. Kanstrup et al. (2014) describe several categories of PD walking methods which may reveal different intentions and approaches. Sometimes these categories of walking methods are complemented with other PD methods:

– *Walking observations* (WO). As with many other PD methods, this walking method is related to ethnographic approaches and is used to immerse researchers into the field in order to learn about practices, activities and behaviours. This could be to walk through a site or specific environment and could be considered as "shadowing" – watching people while they are moving. Usually, this method involves a researcher and a local "actor" and the data collected may act as context triggers, based on real actions, and may inspire design processes.
– *Walking interviews* (WI). As with walking observations, this method typically involves a local actor and researcher(s). The method involves a more explicit intention during the walking activity and is more systematically oriented. This category shares a focus on understanding how people perceive and react to their environments and to understand and make sense of people's living environments, such as informing urban planning.
– *Bimbling* (BIM). Bimbling is defined as "to wander around aimlessly". This method usually involves one local actor and one researcher and its intention is to facilitate thinking while walking. According to Kanstrup et al. (2014), this method intends to unfold "memories" of a place and the activity of the method itself deals with interconnections with a place or places to recall episodes and fragments of meanings at a specific place or environment. However, bimbling is not considered a PD method, but has been recognised as a trigger for design, even though it is unclear what its contribution is.
– *Proto walks* (PW). This method is related to CI and with the increase of mobile devices. It is not so much about understanding the environment in urban planning projects or ethnographical-related studies, but rather about evaluating the mobile technologies as prototypes. Proto walks are about how to evaluate a tool or system in context, that is, in the field. Proto walks are often performed in groups, and group walks have proven to give some interesting results due to the fact that they may exchange with each other the object trying to find a meaning (Lykke & Jantzen, 2013).

– *Transect walk* (TW). A transect walk is a systematic walkthrough of an area, e.g. a stretch of a street, a rural village or an urban setting, to identify resources important to the local community. The method is especially used concerning rural development. The usual procedure includes that residents at a place and researchers meet and collaborate on establishing a first shared overview/map of the area and its resources and their locations. This could be through drawing and brainstorming activities. Based on the map, residents then decide on a walking route to those sites and while walking, they stop to document resources at the identified locations along this route.

In summary, explicit participatory reflections may be rather weak in walking interviews, bimbling and proto walks if not appropriately processed afterwards to provide meaningful information. Several methods argue that walking is a trigger for a design process. However, only walking observations and transect walks describe and propose explicit details on how to facilitate a shared understanding among the participants and how something already known could be reshaped or changed.

3 Walking as a Participatory Method

Walking as a creative research method encourages sensory experiences and serves as a collaborative placemaking strategy (Kothe, 2018). In the split between place and placemaking, the place is regarded to be about the feeling of meaning (Turner & Morrison, 2021; Tornroth et al., 2022) or, as Lefebvre (1991) poses it, it is space where the physical and social landscape is imbued with people's meanings. Places thus emerge from everyday socio-spatial relationships and place-bound practices. This stance highlights the significance of walkable, visual and narrative identity, and placemaking in the context of designing urban futures. Walking approaches promote internal and external branding through the reconsideration of local identity, as well as the importance of neighbourhoods and small towns in constructing local image (Sagaris, 2010; Csurgo & Megyesi, 2016). Furthermore, walking and visual approaches are used to produce strategies and cityscape designs to offer pedestrians safe and pleasant circumstances, as well as to recognise the difficulties associated with creating more liveable and safer urban locations, while also acknowledging the vital function of cityscapes (Careri, 2006; Fang et al., 2016; Stanislav & Chin, 2019; Thibaud, 2000; 2012; White et al., 2023).

Walking and visual approaches focus on the development of novel sorts of places through the enhancement of intangible attributes such as identity, community and the sense of place (Sepe, 2009). The concept behind

co-creative approaches to urban planning concentrates upon the ethics of repressive or imbalanced urban planning regulations, as well as on how PD via walking and visual tools assists ethical placemaking (García-Esparza et al., 2023; García-Esparza & Altaba, 2022). It is also a form of territorial empowerment and education (Estrela & Smaniotto Costa, 2019), it boosts orientation, approximation and connection (Menezes & Mateus, 2017) and it increasing local literacy. On the flip side, walking is an evaluation/assessment method of walkability, the quality of spatial situations based on what is seen and felt by those who travel through a given territorial situation (Aguiar, 2015).

Researchers have explored a variety of design factors that have impacts on the use of public spaces, such as the influence of lighting and noise on people's well-being, as well as how architecture and locations may affect relationships and experiences. This is attributable to human beings' ecological nature, as Eckenwiler (2018) acknowledges, people are "ecological subjects" who are materially, socially and geographically placed. Such a "placed" situation is also the basis for place attachment, as Scannell and Gifford (2010) pose the connection between people and space.

In this context, some historical neighbourhoods, peri-urban areas and even remote areas are at risk of becoming an empty canvas for development due to ageing, decay and exclusion resulting in potential loss to both existing residents and potential newcomers (Granados & Van der Horst, 2020). As a result, there is an urgent need to reconsider planning design practices as an integrated process. Focusing on everyday space productions as a form of heuristic tool for identifying the needs of people going about their daily lives may demonstrate how urban elements such as greening typically become essential in the habits of individuals and how designers can refer to these findings in search of beneficial and proactive improvements (Kühl, 2019; Wennberg et al., 2018).

Planners may be able to improve the pedestrian environment by promoting more objective, effective and complete walking-related plans and interventions. However, additional study on the disparities in walkable locations for different stakeholders, such as adults and elderly or disabled pedestrians, is crucial (Moura et al., 2017). Malone (2016) justified it by referencing the dehumanising nature of urban environments for young people and kids, and Menezes and Mateus (2017) put it in the context of motorised movements, whereas Vodicka and Rishbeth (2022) did it to contextualise conviviality in ethnically mixed neighbourhoods. In this line of thought, fostering social involvement has been highlighted as a critical technique for creating empowerment with favourable consequences on a range of health indicators (Richard et al., 2009) and urban liveability (Nascimento & Pólvora, 2016).

4 Methods, Cases and How Challenges are Addressed

Walking methods to boost PD open up informal dialogue about everyday concerns and memories that help break down communication barriers. This puts the reflective sessions at the core of the research process. In this line, the chapter addresses these aspects, the practicalities of the method and the use of digital tools to manage the process and its results. The walking method, which is typically applied in urban settings as a place-learning experience, will be reflected in this chapter on the basis of three different experiences, bringing together cases from Spain, Slovenia and Portugal. In Spain, the location is a rural area of the Valencia region. In Slovenia, the method was conducted in a high-density neighbourhood popularly called the Russian Tsar, located on the northern outskirts of the capital city of Ljubljana. From Portugal, the experiences will be assessed in Agualva e Mira Sintra, a town on the outskirts of the Lisbon Metropolitan Area with strong suburban characteristics.

These cases share the interest in making use of more creative, simple and efficient methodologies that bring results focused on people in their environment, following the concept of ecological subjects (Eckenwiler, 2018), thus advancing knowledge that is people-based and place-based. Walking as a method in placemaking is also part of the search for experiences out of the box, it is one of the so-called informal planning approaches (Smaniotto Costa, 2021). Such experiences run usually in parallel to formal/statutory planning procedures. It is an informal instrument that seeks to promote mutual understanding and an effective, informal and flexible strategy in spatial planning.

Waking, the iterative exploration and observation of the environment by foot, has qualitative and quantitative aspects and several advantages when compared with other forms of survey and research. Walking itself is not a research method; it must be combined/complemented with other methods and techniques to provide meaningful information. Despite its simplicity, walking as part of the PD process holds some problems that need to be elucidated to better understand the potential and limits of a research method. Reflecting on the three cases exposed, it might be challenging to find representatives from all parts of a community. Choosing a specific location transect walk reflects only this situation. Some ethical issues about the safety and confidentiality of participants can arise. Directed walking may rely on a good impression of their neighbourhood instead of random ones that do not hide ugly aspects. Engaging different groups is another challenge, so a collective experience or a data comparison is of great interest to favour empathic or embodied learning.

5 The Rationale for Walking as a Research Method

A review of the literature on methods that complement walking ones is focused mostly on qualitative evaluations: document review, semi-structured conversations, illustrated walking and interactive observation (Csurgo & Megyesi, 2016). Deep mapping may be developed collaboratively by integrating web-delivered, time-enabled dynamic maps or by contrasting historic photographs with neighbouring present street views on those maps. Finally, maps enable interaction with different geo-visualisations that depict past and actual geographic variations. This type of multimedia story, along with walking and public engagement, aids in the creation of deep ties to place (Anderson et al., 2010; Harner et al., 2017), while enabling the enlargement of knowledge and resources available to the place (Nascimento & Pólvora, 2016).

According to Fang et al. (2016), place meanings may be illustrated using interactive community mapping sessions or living labs using visual data, photo-voice documentation and sound-based studies collected during immersive group walks. These are all instruments, according to Crivellaro et al. (2015), such as historical political archives, counterfactual maps, and comparative image processing that encourage contextual interactions among the institutional and community interests to better correlate the processes that build up cities.

Location data is often used by human–computer interaction and immersive virtual environments practitioners to convey contextual information (e.g. map applications, tourist guides and specific areas of focus) (García-Esparza & Altaba, 2020; Altaba & García-Esparza, 2021; White et al., 2023). Nonetheless, the need to push beyond technology and procedures that "constrain our world to points" for design is long overdue. Researchers are consequently compelled to devise effective strategies for gathering such data. Living Labs, seminars and open inquiries help to encourage this debate of theoretical concerns.

The implementation of interpretative walking within a socio-geographical study demonstrates the immense potential this technique provides for researchers interested in how people interact in and with environments. The interpretative walk, also known as the strolling conversation, has mostly been used in urban neighbourhood, health, transportation and housing studies, where it has proved to be particularly beneficial for discovering interpersonal connections to sites (Mackay et al., 2018). A variety of sound-based study approaches have also been utilised to investigate participants' relationships with the environment. These technologies allow participants to create their walking routes as well as visual and aural creations. Visual and auditory work are components of immersive walks that may be made available to a broader audience, across disciplines and outside academia, via media (Stevenson &

Holloway, 2017). Additionally, "sound walks" can foster occasions of sociability and civic engagement (Doughty & Lagerqvist, 2016).

In practice, the walking method incorporates a variety of complementary actions, such as photo-voice documentation, to engage urban residents in exhibitions, research, workshops, living labs, artmaking, dialogues, tours and field trips, among other activities, with the goal of enabling lay people get involved in imaginative co-creation of space (Breitbart, 1995; Mahmood et al., 2012; Wang, 2020; Smaniotto Costa et al., 2023).

6 Cases

6.1 *Case 1 – the Rural Area of Penyagolosa* (*Spain*)

6.1.1 Location

The small villages in the Penyagolosa mountain range between the Valencia and Aragón regions in Spain have their historic centres and building techniques under assessment through fieldwork. These are ancient villages that nowadays suffer from abandon and decay, despite the relevance of their historical legacy.

6.1.2 Aim

The analysis included observational walking through a combination of WO, BIM and TW techniques during the last six years. The fundamental goal of the study was to bring together professional and resident perspectives on the settings. As a result, the subjects were investigated in participatory discussions to identify common starting points for core landscape heritage ideas to design a new heritage plan. Engagement in the brainstorming process enabled professionals and citizens to form inclusive cross-cutting linkages. This was accomplished by the purposeful identification and evaluation of social, economic and environmental aspects and themes that contribute to the character of the built environment (Altaba & García-Esparza, 2018).

6.1.3 Theoretical Context

The case deals with the conflicts between the conservationist spirit of a place seeking to designate a historic site as a property of cultural interest and the attempts of local inhabitants to pursue socio-cultural development while preserving the historical place. In this regard, problems relating to heritage designation can revolve around fixed ideas about conservation values in dynamic and heterogeneous inhabited rural landscapes. Therefore, the case comes to reveal to what extent the neighbours recognise and show the qualities of the urban setting according to their memories and lifestyle.





FIGURES 2.1 AND 2.2 Visitors and locals in the historical village of Puertomingalvo in Teruel region, 2019
SOURCE: CHAIR OF HISTORIC CENTRES AND CULTURAL ROUTES, UJI

Meetings and interviews were organised to find out how locals regarded the landscape. In the words of Fredheim and Khalaf (2016), value types differ amongst scholars, outsiders and natives, making gaining a thorough interpretation challenging. The landscape character assessment (LCA), which is relevant to varied landscapes and based on scale, inherent traits and value, was utilised in the interviews. An "approved" classification of landscape, on the other hand, reduces it to a monument apart from cultural significance and the symbolic nature of the place (Pendlebury, 2013).

6.1.4 Method: Walking Visits to Historic Centres

- Step 1. Form a group of foreigners and residents to inspect the historic site in question. Define the site and paths to be inspected.
- Step 2. Group street view analysis through inspection walks along the streets, entering public and private buildings, while locals explain architectural details and specific interior and exterior elements and narrate how those crafts relate to their past and present daily life environment (Figure 2.1).
- Step 3. Discuss and engage with locals in a final gathering through other forms of cultural manifestations such as palatable and audible ones (Figure 2.2).

The participatory process aims to empower locals and engage foreigners collectively. The first one looks at enhancing and promoting local pride, knowledge and social relationships, while the second one, encourages a slow tourism initiative by acknowledging the attractiveness and "charm ugliness" of non-predefined walks given first-hand by locals.

The ethical issue not solved yet is the lack of participation of certain groups such as children, young people and immigrants. Middle-aged people and elders actively participated in the action.

6.1.5 Results

Intangible cultural expressions in certain locations contribute to cultural diversity. These circumstances necessitate a unique approach, understanding and negotiation, as well as space for various perspectives regarding what defines local culture and genuineness.

6.2 *Case 2 – Russian Tsar in the Suburbs of Ljubljana* (*Slovenia*)

6.2.1 Location

The neighbourhood of Russian Tsar is one of the high-density residential areas from the 1970s that were constructed in the suburbs of Ljubljana. While it is well connected to the central part of the city with public buses and regional trains, the neighbourhood also has a strong identity as being on the "edge of

the city" as it is literally lying at a threshold of the open landscape that surrounds the city.

6.2.2 Aim

The neighbourhood is nearly 50 years old and requires comprehensive urban regeneration. The building stock does not meeting the contemporary criteria of energy efficiency, the infrastructure (such as water pipes and sewage) needs to be uplifted and the accelerated rate of motorisation is decreasing the quality of open public spaces, to name only a few of the challenges. Besides that, Slovenia went through a process of the privatisation of once common ownership of open spaces and new strategies needed to be developed for the new (and numerous) owners of the plots of land within the neighbourhood. These issues, on the one hand, demand the development of more interdisciplinary approaches to urban regeneration. On the other hand, the active participation of the residents and owners of the properties in the neighbourhood is seen as an essential precondition to making urban regeneration a success (Nikšič, 2021). The specific objective of the activities, through walking and semi-structured conversations (WO and WI techniques) was to reveal the common values that the residents of the neighbourhood share and could be the basis for their common action and co-creation of the future vision of the neighbourhood (Nikšič et al., 2018). The testing bed for the whole process was the central public open space of the neighbourhood called Bratovševa ploščad, which is a large, paved area in the centre of the densest part of the neighbourhood, which at the same time functions as a roof of the parking garage (Figure 2.3). This concrete public space served as a polygon to experiment with walking techniques as a practical approach to developing new urban planning practices.

6.2.3 Theoretical Context

The theoretical framework draws upon three key concepts which contribute to understanding the importance of interdisciplinary approaches, resident participation and ethical considerations in the context of urban planning and community engagement. The interdisciplinarity concept of urban regeneration acknowledges the complex nature of urban environments and the need for diverse expertise to address multifaceted challenges (Evans & Marvin, 2006). Collaborating with experts from various fields (such as architecture, energy efficiency, infrastructure and the social sciences) enables comprehensive and holistic solutions. This concept emphasises the importance of integrating multiple perspectives and disciplines to tackle the diverse challenges



FIGURE 2.3 The central public open space of the Russian Tsar neighbourhood – Bratovševa ploščad, 2016
SOURCE: PHOTO ARCHIVES OF THE HUMAN CITIES PROJECT, URBAN PLANNING INSTITUTE OF THE REPUBLIC OF SLOVENIA (UIRS)

faced by the neighbourhood. The second concept relates to residents' participation – active participation of residents and property owners is seen as an essential precondition for successful urban regeneration (Beriguete et al., 2023; Nikšič, 2021). This concept highlights the importance of involving community members in decision-making processes and empowering them to co-create the future vision of their neighbourhood. Engaging residents fosters a sense of ownership, builds trust and ensures that regeneration initiatives align with residents' aspirations. The last theoretical concept relates to ethical considerations in community engagement for obtaining informed consent, protecting privacy and confidentiality, addressing power imbalances, ensuring diversity and representation, maintaining transparency and delivering community benefits. These principles were embedded from the very start of the process to contribute to a fair and inclusive process that respects the rights and well-being of various participants.

6.2.4 Method: Walking the Neighbourhood

Walking and semi-structured conversations support understanding of residents' notions of living environments in urban regeneration. The walking component involves urban planners and residents exploring the neighbourhood together on foot (Figures 2.4 and 2.5). This approach enables a direct experience of the physical environment, allowing participants to observe and interact with their surroundings. Walking also encourages spontaneous conversations and a deeper understanding of the neighbourhood's assets and challenges. Semi-structured conversations, on the one hand, allowed the professionals to direct the course of the conversation (to provide meaningful and useful inputs for the legally prescribed planning procedures) and, on the other hand, allowed residents to point out the themes that were important to them. These conversations were designed to be informal yet guided, allowing for open dialogue and the sharing of perspectives. The discussions focused on residents' perceptions of the neighbourhood, its strengths, weaknesses and potential solutions to address the regeneration challenges. Urban planners actively listen to the residents' insights and capture their ideas for future improvements.

6.2.5 The Issue to be Solved

Given the complex nature of urban regeneration, an interdisciplinary approach is essential, but not always easy to reach in practice. It requires urban planners to collaborate with experts from various fields such as architecture, energy efficiency, infrastructure and the social sciences. This multidisciplinary perspective ensures comprehensive and holistic solutions that address the diverse challenges faced by the neighbourhood. It is a challenge to get the residents and property owners to be actively involved. If this is not achieved, the trust, which is one of the pillars of the process, may be weak and a sense of community can hardly be fostered, thus endangering the goal of reaching a common future vision.

6.2.6 Ethical Issues

It is important to ensure diverse representation among the participants involved in the walking and conversation activities. This includes considering factors such as age, gender, socio-economic status, ethnicity and cultural background – failure to include a diverse range of perspectives may lead to biased outcomes and exclusion of certain groups. Transparency and accountability must also be considered – urban planners should be transparent about the purpose, methods and outcomes of the walking and conversation activities that are applied. It is also essential to ensure that the activities genuinely



FIGURE 2.4 Residents and professionals found in the Russian Tsar neighbourhood, 2016
SOURCE: PHOTO ARCHIVES OF THE HUMAN CITIES PROJECT, URBAN PLANNING INSTITUTE OF THE REPUBLIC OF SLOVENIA (UIRS)



FIGURE 2.5 A "tactile" walk offered a unique barefoot experience of Bratovševa ploščad, 2016
SOURCE: PHOTO ARCHIVES OF SKUPAJ NA PLOŠČADI

benefit the community and contribute to the improvement of residents' living environments. The process should not be exploitative or solely aimed at extracting information without providing tangible benefits or addressing identified issues.

6.2.7 Results

The combination of walking and semi-structured conversations provides a valuable method for urban planners to gain insights into residents' notions of their living environments during urban regeneration processes. By actively involving residents and owners of properties, planners can uncover common values and encourage the co-creation of a shared vision for the neighbourhood's future. This approach fosters community engagement, promotes interdisciplinary collaboration and, ultimately, leads to more sustainable and inclusive urban regeneration initiatives.

6.3 *Case 3 – Agualva e Mira Sintra* (*Portugal*)

6.3.1 Location

Agualva e Mira Sintra is a civil parish of the municipality of Sintra. A parish is the third level of administrative organisation in Portugal, and it oversees

providing local services to the community. Agualva e Mira Sintra is located in the Metropolitan Area of Lisbon, on its outskirts. It is an ancient village that grew up clustered on the train track between Lisbon and Sintra in the course of the urban sprawl of Lisbon. It is a very multicultural community.

6.3.2 Aim

This case is based on several research activities performed by the Research Group on CIDATE – Citizen science in understanding and transforming the territory (https://urbanismo.ulusofona.pt/en/urbanismo-lusofona-en/research/), in collaboration with the parish council of Agualva e Mira Sintra. Backed by the good collaborative atmosphere between both institutions, the research group of the university organised different activities to get students involved in "real-world" cases. The walkscape (Careri, 2006) centred on the play between the build-up environment and greenspaces. Agualva e Mira Sintra's cityscape consists mainly of functional four- to five-storey houses, simply organised around soulless streetscapes and two parks (Bela Vista and Dom Domingos Jardo) created along the Ribeira das Jardas (Figure 2.6), a small stream that recovered became the ecological backbone of this peripheral



FIGURE 2.6 The Jardas stream, after its regeneration in the 2000s, is increasingly being regarded not more as a threat but an asset
PHOTO: CIDATE ARCHIVES, 2023

area in continuous development. The RUMOS project has two goals. First, as a seed project, it seeks to introduce and engage students in research activities to increase their capabilities to solve spatial problems. Attached to this goal is the objective of the Research Group on CIDATE to increase the experiences and knowledge of walking as a research method. Second, the project seeks to provide insights to the parish council about the walkability of the area, using WO, WI and TW techniques, and thus provide information for urban policies.

6.3.3 Theoretical Context

The foundation of the research is based on the concepts of citizen science, the involvement of lay people in research in spatial planning (Simon et al., 2023), participatory planning and action research equipped with techniques from tactical urbanism (Healey, 2006; Menezes & Mateus, 2017).

A toolkit was organised, consisting of different tools the students should apply in the field work, considering the methods of walking observations, walking interviews, proto walks and transect walks. The toolkit consisted of a field diary, instructions for capturing different situations for observing the surroundings and interview guidelines for approaching people met during their walking activities. Thus, very diverse outcomes are achieved. Their analysis, also regarding the qualitative data, is still in process, and based on thematic analysis as proposed by Braun and Clarke (2006), will certainly provide more insights on the walkability in Agualva e Mira Sintra.

6.3.4 Method: Walking in Everyday Spaces

Considering that Agualva e Mira Sintra is an appendage of Lisbon and a relatively new urban development, the study focused on those spaces and places of everyday life (Figure 2.7). It is thus to enrich the pool of knowledge on the values that can be attributed to this setting – the build-up areas and greenspaces and each of its elements.

For the assessment of results, different techniques are being used – such as visual analysis of cartographic, photographic and video graphic material; content analysis for narratives and texts; and speech analysis for interviews.

6.3.5 Ethical Issues

The research in Agualva e Mira Sintra, although it matched the specific local conditions, posed some challenges that limited the outreach of the results. First, the participants were students, although sensibilised to spatial issues, they do not live in the area; therefore, they were primed beforehand to question what they see while walking together. This also raises the question about the limited constellation of stakeholders. However, considering the goals of the RUMOS project, these issues can be disregarded.



FIGURE 2.7
A typical car-dominated streetscape in Agualva e Mira Sintra
PHOTO: CIDATE ARCHIVES, 2023

6.3.6 Results

The assessment of results has not yet been finished, as the project is still running. The results are planned to be concluded at the end of 2023. During the analysis and assessment different workshops are being planned – also to diminish the limitations of the research.

6.3.7 Discussion

The cases draw attention to the importance of walking as a methodology for analysing the environment and as a way of getting acquainted – finding one's orientation – in unknown spaces. In the rural area of Penyagolosa, adopting a long-term urban landscape strategy is critical for appropriately contextualising contemporary transformation (Emanuelson, 2009). Heritage additionally involves the communication, transmission and upgrading of information and ideas. It is about defining and expressing one's identity as well as recreating the cultural and social principles and values that support the construction of local identity. Another advantage of the walking methods is the increased engagement of citizens through a newer and more open attitude to a larger perception of cultural assets. A feeling of community, collective ownership and awareness should be part of a larger cultural evolution towards a society, assisting in the discovery of common cultural values. The instance disclosed in the Penyagolosa rural area of Valencia has significant challenges that condition these settings with the rest of the Spanish state and certain rural parts

of Europe. Depopulation, environmental degradation or the disappearance of cultural assets as an incentive to establish points of departure for better futures aided in unifying analytical criteria and focusing debate participation on observing effectively from within the attitude toward those issues and proposing strategies aimed at reversing them.

The case study of the Russian Tsar in Ljubljana offers valuable insights into the importance of active resident participation in interdisciplinary urban regeneration processes. By engaging residents in walking and semi-structured conversations, urban planners gained a direct experience of the physical environment and fostered open dialogue with community members. This approach not only allowed for a deeper understanding of residents' perceptions, strengths and challenges of the neighbourhood but also encouraged the co-creation of a shared vision for the neighbourhood's future, as well as resulted in some concrete design proposals for the central square of the neighbourhood. An important aspect of this case study is the ethical considerations embedded throughout the process. By being transparent about the purpose and outcomes of the activities, and by having an "open door policy" (everyone was welcome), the case study promotes inclusivity and accountability. It emphasises the importance of respecting the rights and well-being of all community members, by choosing a simple while well-tailored method of walking and talking. By doing so, trust, a feeling of ownership and a sense of community among attendees were elevated. The case also demonstrates the effectiveness of walking methods as a place-learning experience for PD in urban regeneration.

Although the assessment of the data collected in Agualva e Mira Sintra is still in progress, some insights can already be distilled. First, walking is an easy and simple work method to call the attention of participants to the ground and to the surroundings they walk through. Thus, it is an interesting tool for place-learning experiences. Second, regarding walkability, the assessment of problems encountered and annotated by the participants reveals that not all urban places provide a welcoming environment for walking. As a research methodology, walking proved to be able to bring together different stakeholders to a common arena and forge conversations among them. This is per se an important result, as it can enrich the body of spatial and social knowledge – which is of increasing relevance in societies faced with huge and complex multi-diversity issues, as in the case of Agualva e Mira Sintra. In this respect, a local government that is fitted with appropriate knowledge and devices can better promote social integration (Figure 2.8).

The theoretical contribution steaming from the cases brings us back to the main questions of the appropriateness of walking for a place-learning experience and for PD. The key takeaways are related to walking as a multifaceted technique for PD.



FIGURE 2.8 Students taking observation notes during a walking exercise in Agualva e Mira Sintra
PHOTO: CIDATE ARCHIVES, 2023

Through cases, walking has proven to be a method very suitable for studying and understanding the urban and rural environments and to parse the complex interplay of physical, social and cultural aspects; a set of collaborative methods that approach planning offering dialogue and inclusivity to shape the social space (Zabielskis, 2008). As the case of Agualva e Mira Sintra pinpointed, dedicated strolling and observation offer an opportunity to walkers for identifying and understanding the space. To do this, the participants should be able to detect an observation point, mark (or identify) it on the map and look around, broadening their horizon and opening it for also depicting atmospheres and ambiences, as suggested by Thibaud (2000). As exposed in all cases, sharing the same spaces enables the participants to interact with the locals, to capture their experiences and memories, enriching the pool of local knowledge. The results from Agualva e Mira Sintra show that participants once imbued with the right tools are eager to develop and provide ideas for future action.

As in the case of Penyagolosa, walking tours in place are being used to reverse a not-very-attractive situation. Making use of the attractiveness and charm of the ugliness, these are driving the acknowledgement that such places also embody values. Such insights can reveal relevant issues such as the appropriateness of the cities to respond to the abilities and aesthetical concerns of people. Insights that urban planning and government directives too often ignore. In line with Metzger (2014), placemaking is a process about ethics and empowers communities for reasons that are not obvious (heritage, climate etc.). The triangulation of both formal and informal knowledge could result in a more valid foundation for future planning interventions. PD, supported by walking methods, can contribute to a common goal – transforming urban

spaces into more liveable environments (Murphy et al., 2019). The different scales outlined and analysed in the three cases reflect the importance of cultural interpretive transmigrations which help to create lasting structures for the reinforcement of governance and values.

Walking as a placemaking technique is the opposite of a linear policy (and research) design, which has been shown inadequate to tackle complex societal challenges. It is also a valuable mechanism to boost innovation and commitment. Thus, walking methods are well suited to work in non-linear urban innovation ecosystems with multi-stakeholder participation and diverse knowledge practices as evidenced by the three different cases. On the flip side, such innovation ecosystems also call for changes in governance. Following Foth (2017) the Slovenian case study showed, the walking method combined with conversations is a useful approach that brings urban planners and residents together and strengthens their collaboration within a common goal – to provide better living environments. An increase in the interaction between governments and citizens provokes a decentralised and more democratic approach to the production of space and the use of resources (OECD, 2020). Once citizens become co-creators, they should also share responsibilities. A citizen-based and government-fed development offers opportunities for all, for mutual learning and sharing between governments and citizens.

Walking brings about important and reliable qualitative insights into planning and research on urban environments. It increases thus the validity of qualitative methods, and it is on the flip side, a method when well flanked and supported by other methods and techniques, is a simple tool to bring people to think about the city and their role in its production (Estrela & Smaniotto Costa, 2019). It also helps to "disclose" unexpected plays of social and spatial contexts, as asserted by Pierce and Lawhon (2015). This enables a better-tailored urban policy. Its informal character has two benefits: first, it empowers people to understand and reason about their environment and this, in turn, can be a way to make them more aware of their power and, second, such "informal" results can be inserted in the formal planning system, making the insights a dynamic contribution to placemaking.

7 Conclusion

The utilisation of pedestrian-oriented techniques as a placemaking instrument challenges the bitten practices of design approaches and encourages the dedication of both professional and civic stakeholders. It facilitates non-linear urban innovation ecosystems with the involvement of multiple stakeholders and diverse knowledge practices. Walking brings dependable qualitative insights to urban planning and research, enhancing the validity of qualitative

methods and facilitating a better comprehension of the city and individual roles in its creation. The casual nature of walking empowers individuals to interact with and rationalise their surroundings, while the resultant insights can be incorporated into the official planning system, actively contributing to placemaking endeavours.

The chapter brings forward three cases that use participatory research aiming to democratise decision-making, enhance user engagement and address everyday issues. The experience in the cases shows how the beneficiary is a guided experience of people with their physical environment, it is more than an aesthetic experience (Agualva e Mira Sintra) as it raises awareness for people's well-being (Russian Tsar) and the construction of local identity (Penyagolosa). The three cases illustrate the evidence of walking as a means to build and share a vision for more people-friendly urban environments. In all cases, bringing together different stakeholders to a common arena for an open dialogue enriches the body of spatial and social knowledge which is of increasing relevance in societies faced with huge and complex multi-diversity issues.

Thus, cases demonstrate the validity of an iterative approach in various sectors and design contexts, urban – rural, and social – cultural. Among the participatory design, the chapter introduces walking methods complemented with other PD methods such as observations, interviews, bimbling, proto walks and transect walks. As exposed in cases, a challenge exists to find a set of individuals representative of the community and to limit the study to specific transects which narrows the analysis to a particular situation.

The chapter demonstrates how walking techniques lay the groundwork for further research and underscore the significance of spatial and social knowledge. By embracing walking as a tool for placemaking, cities and villages can harness the potential of citizen engagement and participation to shape vibrant and people-centric built environments. This chapter thus devolves a conceptual foundation for current and future research on walking as a tool for placemaking. The cases show that spatial and social knowledge, through research, and technology-led innovation, are indispensable to meet this challenge. A relevant objective of future research has to do with how decision-makers interpret and incorporate these ethnographic methods to the urban, social and cultural realm.

Funding

Part of this chapter has been funded by the Ministerio de Ciencia, Innovación y Universidades, MCIN/AEI/10.13039/501100011033 (grant no. PID2019-105197RA-I00), and by the Chair of Historic Centres and Cultural Routes at the Universitat Jaume I. The Portuguese case is based on the RUMOS project,

co-funded by the Programme Seeds of Instituto Lusófono de Investigação e Desenvolvimento (ILIND) with funds from the Fundação de Ciência e Tecnologia (FCT), contract no. PE-CEIED-3/003/2022. The case study of Ljubljana was partly supported by the Slovenian Research Agency (research core funding no. P5-0100).

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